

ZUBEEN GARG 36

PROFESSION Singer, music director

PROVENANCE Assam

CLAIM TO FAME Shot into limelight with the song *Ya Ali* from *Gangster*. Has sung several other songs such as *Jhoom Barabar Jhoom*.

CURRENT STATUS Composed music for the yet-to-be released Hindi movie *As the River Flows*. Planning to produce and direct three films; two in Assamese and one in Hindi.



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North-eastern youth won't stay on the sidelines any longer. From winning talent hunts to writing plays, mainstream fame is closer than it used to be.

By Nirmala Ravindran

It's official. Baichung Bhutia won the reality show *Jhalak Dikhla Ja 3* earlier this year, thanks to the millions of votes that came in from the North-eastern states of India. Sikkim didn't sleep for weeks trying to garner votes for Bhutia's win. Gangtok alone sent in more than 50,000 votes to crown the ace footballer the new dancing star. One organisation collected Rs 1.5 lakh to buy mobile recharge cards while another bought 10,000 cards for voting. But the first reality show contestant to ignite such passion in the North-east was Debajit Saha from Assam, whose victory in Zee TV's *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa* in 2005, blurred the divide between the the Assamese-dominated Brahmaputra Valley and the Bengali-dominated Barak Valley of the state. For the first time, people from both valleys stood united for this Bengali son of Assam. The seven sisters voted together again in 2008 for Meghalaya's Amit Paul who was runner's up in *Indian Idol 3* on Sony TV. And this year, the same wave swept Sourabhee Debbarma from Tripura to the top of the heap in *Indian Idol*.

The North-east, it seems, is like an idea whose time has suddenly come. Always rich in culture and tradition, today the region is ready more than ever to join mainstream India. In every field, talented youngsters are overcoming prejudices to make it big on the